DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Why Sacrifices? The Korbanot in Our Morning Prayer

Derech Hashem 4:6:10

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 4, Chapter 6, paragraph 10 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 14 March 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Ready to pray

The Rabbi reviewed the order of the morning so far: washing the hands to remove the impurity of the night, sisit as our insignia as servants of God, tefillin to bring down the shefa, with the head tefillin greater than the arm, and the questions of Shabbat, Yom Tov and Hol HaMoed. Once a person has sisit and tefillin, he is ready to pray.

The four parts of prayer

Paragraph 10 divides the morning prayer into four parts:

1. The korbanot, the passages about the sacrifices.
2. Pesukei DeZimra, the verses of praise.
3. Shema and its blessings.
4. The Amidah and everything after it.

The Rabbi pointed out that the Ramhal counts the korbanot as one of the four parts of the service. It is an important part and one cannot simply drop it, even though, if pressed for time, it is the first thing to skip, and Shema certainly comes first.

The purpose of the korbanot each morning is to purify the world and remove anything that prevents the flow of positive energy from coming down. A participant noted that we read them as a replacement for the sacrifices of the Temple, "our lips in place of bulls." The Rabbi agreed, but stressed the question: what is the purpose of the korbanot themselves?

Korban means coming near

Since the Torah readings were then Vayikra and Sav, the Rabbi spoke a little about sacrifices. The word korban comes from karov, to come near. The prophets have beautiful verses where God says: do I want the blood of your sacrifices? I reject all of it; I want you to come near. The korban is only a medium for joining with Hakadosh Barukh Hu. The problem is that such

things become rituals, and people give significance to the korban itself. "Korban has no significance in and of itself."

He recalled the Ramban in Parashat Vayikra: the person bringing a korban must think, as it is slaughtered, that really this should be happening to me.

How can we kill animals to come close to God?

The Rabbi raised the question people fairly ask: we care about animals, so how can we spill their blood to come close to God? One participant said he could not see how ending another creature's existence brings a person nearer to God. Another suggested two answers: the animal was created for this purpose, and the Torah allowed sacrifices because the people were used to idol worship.

The Rabbi began with the eglah arufah. When a murdered body is found and the killer is unknown, the elders of the nearest town take a young calf, break its neck, and its blood flows into the stream, and the whole town comes out to watch. The Abarbanel asks: the town has just seen a gruesome corpse, and now we kill another creature? His answer: sometimes you have to do gruesome things to wake people up. "Maybe if I show you blood in your eyes, you'll recognise what it means." It is not nice for the animal, but if it improves people, it is worthwhile. The korban works the same way: the person leans his hands on it and sees that it should be happening to him.

He added that animals deserve respect but come nowhere near the value of a human life. He recalled the outcry a few years ago when a gorilla in a zoo was shot after a small child got into its enclosure: if there is any chance a child is in danger, the animal is killed at once. Concern for animals is wonderful, he said, but not when it takes focus away from human beings.

So God says: if you just bring sacrifices and spill blood and nothing happens to you, I do not want them. Then the korban becomes a way to feel good about yourself. The Rabbi applied this to donations given to ease one's conscience, and to rushing through the prayer book without understanding what we read.

A participant added that most korbanot were not sin offerings; many were eaten, and a peace offering is like a gift between friends to improve the relationship. The Rabbi agreed.

The Rambam and the Ramban

The participant's second answer, the Rabbi said, is the Rambam's opinion, which is very controversial. The Rambam held that sacrifices are not ideal. God allowed them because Israel at that time was so used to sacrifice that if it had been banned outright, they would have gone and sacrificed to idols. So God said: offer sacrifices, but only to Me.

The Rabbi compared this to how the Torah handles slavery and the captive woman in war: if something is going to happen anyway, better to regulate it than ban it, just as some argue about legalising drugs. The Torah allows a slave and regulates how he is treated; it allows the captive woman but only after a process meant to cool the desire.

The Ramban, however, strongly disagreed with the Rambam, since that view seems to make the whole book of Vayikra only for its time. The Rabbi said he agrees with the Ramban.

Pesukei DeZimra and the blessings of Shema

The purpose of Pesukei DeZimra is to reveal God's light through the praises we say. When we sing that everything comes from Him, the angels, the snow, the rain, the wind, we recognise Him in this world, connect to Him and bring His light down. A participant suggested that the korbanot and the songs mirror what was done in the Temple, where the Levites sang; the Rabbi found it an interesting idea.

On the blessings of Shema, the Ramhal goes into Kabbalah. Everything in existence comes through a chain, from the root forces down to the physical world. For the energy to come down, every link of the chain must be strengthened, from the lowest to the highest, until it reaches the root. "If the ladder is strong, the energy will come down well." That is why the blessings speak of the sun, moon and stars, then of the different levels of angels, the Seraphim and the Hayyot: we are joining each link back to Hakadosh Barukh Hu. Once the chain is made, we can ask, in the Amidah, and the energy comes down.

The next paragraph, on the Amidah, becomes very kabbalistic, on the names of God and why the three Avot. The class resumes the following Monday.

Summary

- Morning prayer has four parts: korbanot, Pesukei DeZimra, Shema with its blessings, and the Amidah with what follows.
- The korbanot remove what blocks the flow of blessing; korban means coming near, and the act has no value without inner change.
- Like the eglah arufah in the Abarbanel's explanation, a sacrifice shocks a person into seeing that it should have been him.
- The Rambam saw sacrifices as a concession to the people of the time; the Ramban strongly disagreed, and the Rabbi sides with the Ramban.
- Pesukei DeZimra reveal God in nature; the blessings of Shema build the chain of links up to Him before we ask in the Amidah.

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